

PAWAN BHAWAR

STUDENTS AT
THE RESIDENTIAL
SCHOOLS IN
BETUL (FAR LEFT)
AND INDORE



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SALINA SINGH, Commissioner of Scheduled Castes Development Department

want to become an IAS officer,” he declares. The school is jointly run by the state Scheduled Caste and Tribal Development Departments.

That the Government is pouring money into residential schools is evident from the facilities available. The campus is walled and the school is spacious and airy. Hostel rooms are big and the students have access to all facilities, like food, uniforms, books, stationery and other articles of daily need, free of cost. “These schools are symbolic of the possibilities that can be tapped amongst disadvantaged communities,” says Salina Singh, commissioner of the Scheduled Castes Development Department. Adds D.D. Shrivastava, principal of the school, “We had a 100 per cent record in the Class X Board exams in the last academic session. This shows that the concept works and things are on the right track.”

However, there is a significant difference between Dalit and tribal schools. While the former have

continued to follow the syllabus of the state Board of Secondary Education, the Eklavya schools for tribal students have adopted the CBSE syllabus. Eklavya School in Betul district boasted of a 97 per cent result in Class XII. In operation since 2003, the school has 352 students, of whom 132 are girls. Admissions to such schools take place on the basis of a screening test after Class VI. Says principal B.P. Bakoria, Eklavya School, “Ever since Central aid began pouring in for the school, the syllabus changed to CBSE.” The students at a model school created ripples last year when they reached the finals of the national junior softball. That sparked off a sports culture in the nearby schools of Shahpur and Bhaunra which Bakoria now wants to foster in his own school. “Students from tribal communities have always excelled at anything they set out to do. It comes from the lack of distractions in their lifestyle,” says Anil Garg, a local activist.

The Government runs only one residential school in each of the seven

divisions of the state. There are only 13 Eklavya schools in the tribal-dominated districts of the state. Together, they form a small percentage of the vast number of students in the state. Against the 6,57,574 general category students who took the high school exam under the MP Board, only 208 were Dalit students studying in the government-run residential schools. Of the 182 who completed the exams, 151 students (83 per cent) passed with a first division, 30 managed a second division and one got a third division. In the higher secondary exam under the MP Board, 112 Dalit students took the exam of which 97 passed, 69 got a first division and 29 passed with a second division. Such results can be replicated in the entire state if the Government pumps in massive funds and methodology. Till then, the sparkling performance of the disadvantaged students attending these residential schools will continue to stand out like a beacon. ■